UX RESEARCH CASE STUDY

API COMMUNITY OF PRACTICE

FROM FRAGMENTED CAPABILITY TO CONNECTED ECOSYSTEM

Client: a leading South African financial institution

Role: UX Designer

Team of 7

Shared under NDA. Client identity, verbatim findings and internal artefacts are anonymised or generalised. The Community of Practice has not been built or shipped.

This case study covers

- ● Problem
- ● Research method & thinking
- ● Synthesis & insights
- ● Collaboration & influence
- ● Design direction
- ● Solution & design decisions
- ● Success & impact
- ● Lessons learned & next steps

Team of 7: 5 UX/UI designers, 1 design lead and 1 UI designer. I was one of the UX designers, working on the research.

No screens to show: the Community of Practice hasn't shipped and its artefacts are under NDA. This case study shows the research, reasoning and decisions instead.

CHAPTER 01 OF 08

Problem

- Problem statement
- How might we
- The ask, the gap, the constraint

Teams couldn't trust, find or reuse what already existed

PROBLEM STATEMENT

A leading South African financial institution had a live API Marketplace but no evidence of whether teams trusted, found or reused what was on it. Leadership suspected collaboration, discoverability and reuse were breaking down, yet had no structured evidence of where or why. Without it, the proposed API Community of Practice risked being designed on assumptions.

How might we design a Community of Practice around how people actually discover, trust and reuse APIs?

The ask

Establish qualitative evidence of how the live Marketplace was being experienced, to inform the Community of Practice.

The gap

No structured evidence of where or why collaboration, discoverability and reuse were breaking down.

The constraint

Contracted under NDA, so client identity, org structure and verbatim quotes are withheld or generalised.

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Research method & thinking

- Four objectives
- Five-step method
- Protocol design
- 16 stakeholder interviews

Four objectives shaped every question I wrote

1. Understand how the API ecosystem is experienced across product, platform, architecture, engineering, delivery and business teams.
2. Identify barriers and opportunities in collaboration, discoverability, reuse and knowledge-sharing.
3. Assess organisational readiness for an API Community of Practice and broader ecosystem enablement.
4. Establish qualitative indicators of ecosystem maturity to inform the design, operating model and governance approach.

A five-step path from raw conversation to strategic theme

1. **Design protocol** Objectives, flow, prompts
2. **Recruit & brief** Cross-functional stakeholders
3. **Interview** 30–45 min, think-aloud
4. **Affinity map** Cluster raw data into patterns
5. **Synthesize** Themes, maturity, recommendations

Protocol: behaviour, not opinion

- Opened with consent, framing and a think-aloud instruction: psychological safety, not evaluation.
- Sequenced context → current state → delivery behaviour → culture → future vision, so trust built before friction.
- Used scenario prompts ("imagine a change is made to a shared API…") to get concrete behaviour.
- Wrote a separate executive track: same themes, different altitude.

The protocol, briefly

Opening	Consent, framing, think-aloud (3–5 min)
Their context	Role, ecosystem relationship, discovery habits (5–7 min)
Current state	What works, friction, reinvention (10–12 min)
Delivery behaviour	Scenario-based reuse and governance probes (10–12 min)
Culture & readiness	Knowledge-sharing, incentives, community appetite (8 min)
Future state & close	2-year vision, biggest lever, referrals (8 min)

16 interviews across 7 stakeholder groups, 30–45 minutes each, recorded with consent for analysis only.

Solution architects · SMEs · Business analysts · Developers · UX designers · Heads of APIs · Executives

Framed as diagnosis

Told every stakeholder this wasn't a performance evaluation, which opened candour about workarounds.

Named the observers

Silent note-takers were disclosed upfront, protecting trust mid-conversation.

Followed the energy

Open prompts like "walk me through a recent example" chased specificity.

Watched for what wasn't said

Hesitation and vague answers about ownership were as telling as complaints.

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Synthesis & insights

- Affinity mapping
- 20 insights, six themes
- Three plain-language insights

From interview transcripts to defensible themes

1. **Fragment** One observation per note, stripped of speaker identity.
2. **Cluster** Grouped bottom-up by underlying behaviour, not by question.
3. **Label** Named each cluster as a pattern and checked it across stakeholder groups.
4. **Weight & prioritise** Scored by frequency, intensity and business impact.

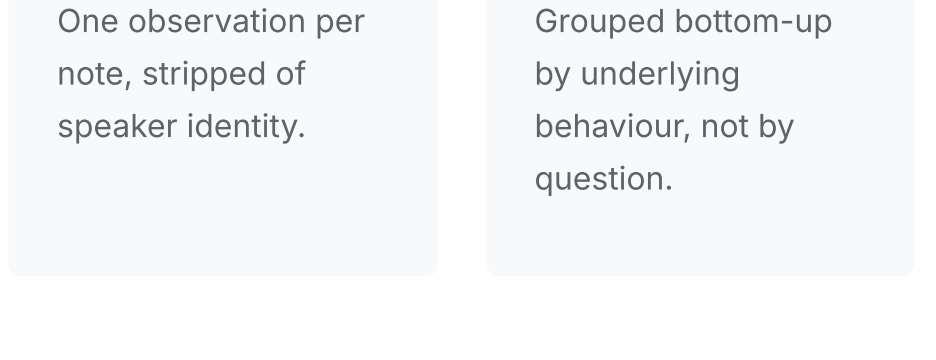

Illustration only. The real board is obscured under NDA.

16 interviews

20 insights, sharpened from patterns into numbered statements

I ran the affinity session as a facilitated exercise with the wider team, debating what a pattern meant before it became a finding.

Six themes emerged; the deepest ran behavioural

Discovery is people-dependent
Teams found APIs through personal networks, not systems.

Fragmented ownership
Unclear accountability discouraged reuse.

Duplication is normalised
Rebuilding felt lower-risk than trusting someone else's work.

Governance felt like a gate
Process meant delay, not enablement.

Deep-rooted habits
"How we've always done it" outweighed a new shared model.
DEEPEST

Incentives don't reward reuse
Recognition favoured shipping something new.
DEEPEST

What the themes mean, in plain language

1. **People over platforms**
   INSIGHT Teams trusted people they knew over what the platform listed.
   IMPLICATION Findable owners and named contacts beside every API.
2. **Rebuilding feels safer**
   INSIGHT Building fresh was lower-risk than finding and vetting.
   IMPLICATION Lower the cost of trusting a shared API.
3. **Reuse has no payoff**
   INSIGHT Reuse costs effort without credit.
   IMPLICATION Recognise reuse and contribution as valued work.

Worded generally to protect the client. These three are distilled from the six themes.

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Collaboration & influence

- A team of seven
- What I owned, what we shared
- Facilitating with the bank

A team of seven, working from one shared board

UX/UI designer **Me** · UX/UI designer · UX/UI designer · UX/UI designer · UX/UI designer · Design lead · UI designer

What I owned

- The interview protocol
- 9 of the 16 interviews
- Facilitating the affinity mapping exercise and the ideation session

What we shared as a team of 7

- Reviewing the patterns before they became findings
- The machine-to-organism reframe we recommended to leadership

How I influenced the outcome

1. **Made synthesis a team exercise**
   Debating each pattern before it became a finding gave the final themes credibility with leadership.
2. **Worked on one board with the bank**
   The people who will run the Community of Practice helped shape it, so the ideas were theirs.
3. **Gave leadership a shared vocabulary**
   "Machine vs organism" made trade-offs quick to discuss.

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Design direction

- Machine to organism
- What the evidence asks of the design

From a machine to an organism

Because the deepest blockers were habits and incentives, tooling alone (the Marketplace platform) wouldn't fix them. We recommended reframing the Community of Practice's operating model itself.

Today: the Machine model

- Fixed parts and processes, designed once and expected to run unchanged
- Central control; teams execute a defined sequence
- Efficient when stable, brittle when context shifts
- Reuse and collaboration are process steps, not rewarded behaviours

Proposed: the Organism model

- Self-organising parts that sense conditions and adapt
- Distributed ownership: everyone tends the ecosystem
- Resilient as teams, priorities and technology shift
- Reuse and contribution are incentivised as healthy behaviour

What the evidence asks of the design

Make people part of discovery
Owners and contacts are findable beside every API.

Make trust cheap
Reuse becomes the easy default, rebuilding the effort.

Recognise reuse
Credit contribution and reuse as valued work.

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Solution & design decisions

- Three decisions
- The ideation session
- Why there are no screens

Three design decisions, grounded in evidence

1. **People over platforms**
   INSIGHT Teams trusted people they knew over what the platform listed.
   DECISION Make people part of discovery: findable owners and named contacts beside every API.
   REJECTED A platform-only fix such as better listings or search.
2. **Make reuse the easy default**
   INSIGHT Building fresh felt lower-risk than finding and vetting.
   DECISION Lower the cost of trusting a shared API so reuse becomes the default.
   REJECTED More governance gates, which already felt like delay.
3. **Reward reuse**
   INSIGHT Recognition and delivery pressure favoured shipping something new.
   DECISION Recognise reuse and contribution as valued work, not extra process.
   REJECTED Treating reuse as another compliance step.

The ideation session, built with the bank

1. **Shared back the insights** Walked everyone through the affinity map so we worked from the same evidence.
2. **Reframed as questions** "Why should I change, and how do I do it?"
3. **Diverged together** Mixed groups generated ideas across journeys, habits and benefits.
4. **Converged on priorities** Grouped ideas and starred the ones the room rallied behind.

Shared ownership
The people who will run it helped shape it.

Tested in the room
The bank confirmed, challenged or sharpened insights before anything was designed.

Co-created change
People change habits they help redesign, which a report alone can't do.

Why there are no screens here

The Community of Practice hasn't been built or shipped, and its artefacts are under NDA. The decisions above are the design work so far: they set what the experience must do before any interface exists.

CHAPTER 07 OF 08

Success & impact

- Where this stands
- What it contributed
- How success could be judged

Delivered as the evidence base for leadership

The themes, maturity read and machine-to-organism reframe were delivered to leadership as the evidence base for the Community of Practice's design.

A traceable evidence base
Every theme maps back to multiple stakeholder voices, not anecdote.

A reframed problem
A culture and incentive challenge as much as a platform one.

A shared vocabulary
"Machine vs organism" gave leadership a fast way to discuss trade-offs.

How success could be judged PROPOSED

Findable
Teams can find an API and its owner without asking around.

Reused
Teams choose reuse over rebuilding more often.

Recognised
Reuse and contribution show up in how work is credited.

Proposed indicators, to validate with the client. There are no usage results because the Community of Practice isn't live yet.

CHAPTER 08 OF 08

Lessons learned & next steps

- Reflection
- Lessons
- Next steps

What I'm taking forward

Reflection

The deepest blockers were rarely technical. I only caught that by staying close to the work, from protocol through synthesis, alongside the wider team.

What I'd do differently

Protect that continuity earlier in a project, and check whether the real barrier is habits or behaviour before reaching for a tooling fix.

Lessons

1. **Stay close, end to end** Continuity from protocol to synthesis surfaced the subtle signals.
2. **Name the barrier first** Habits and incentives need a different fix than tooling.
3. **Co-create with the owners** People defend what they helped build.

Next steps PROPOSED

1. **Design the operating model** Shape the Community of Practice's model and governance with the bank's stakeholders.
2. **Pilot people-first discovery** Try named owners and recognition with one or two teams.
3. **Re-measure behaviour** Repeat a lighter round of interviews to see whether behaviour shifts.

Thank you for reading my case study

Hope you enjoyed it. 🌱

Plant a seed

Every ecosystem starts with one connection.

Stanslous Nhau · UX Designer · Johannesburg, South Africa

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